

US felt it was lagging behind the Soviet Union in military research. DARPA's research projects have not been confined to the military sphere: the concepts of networking and the Internet, hypertext, and GPS are some of its project spin-offs. Douglas Engelbart, the inventor of the mouse, was associated with DARPA.

April: Japan uses the parametron for its first computer

The NEAC 1101, Japan's first computer, was built by NEC as a prototype. It was a parametron-based computer, the parametron being a cheap component, though slower than the transistor. The NEAC 1101 was designed for scientific and engineering use and was the first Japanese computer to use floating point operations. This computer was instrumental in development of NEC's later parametron computers.

May / June: ALGOL, rather an important language

ALGOL (ALGOrithmic Language), an important computer language, was developed by a group of American and European computer scientists at Zurich. It was introduced to deal with some of the problems faced while working with FORTRAN and was used mainly by the scientific community. Later revisions, notably in 1960, were influential in the development of almost all future computer languages—and also led directly to the development of Pascal, a language that was used for introducing students to programming.

September: The Integrated Circuit

Jack Kilby at Texas Instruments invented the Integrated Circuit in September 1958, an invention that opened the doors to the digital age. Electronic circuits prior to the IC consisted of capacitors, transistors, resistors, and many other components individually connected by wires. Such designs occupied a lot of space and were unreliable. In the IC, every component is made of silicon, actually an extension of a tiny silicon wafer and connected by almost invisible wires. The whole set up consumes very low power, is cheap to manufacture and is very small (modern ICs pack about 1 million transistors per square millimetre). The IC is at the heart of any-